



Phase 1:

Important but Delegable Tasks in Theory Development

Version 0.0

Introductory note

This is a list of tasks that are important for theory development, but that can often be carried out collaboratively or delegated to other experts. These tasks support the development, evaluation, communication, application, and maintenance of theories, but they are not necessarily core tasks that every theoretical psychologist must personally perform.

The list distinguishes **delegable execution** from **non-delegable theoretical responsibility**. Technical, empirical, formal, infrastructural, applied, and communicative work may often require collaboration with empirical psychologists, psychometricians, statisticians, computational modelers, software developers, designers, domain specialists, or applied researchers. However, the theoretical responsibility cannot be delegated completely. The theorist remains responsible for clarifying what is being measured, formalized, tested, archived, communicated, or applied, and how this work bears on the theory.

These tasks were identified through expert feedback in Phase 1, Round 1 of the ECTO project. They are listed separately from the eight core responsibilities to make clear that they are important for theory development, but are not always tasks that the theorist must execute personally.



Important but delegable tasks

1. **Technical measurement development and psychometric validation**

Building scales, tests, items, indices, measurement models, reliability analyses, validity studies, measurement-invariance tests, and other technical measurement procedures can be carried out by measurement specialists. The theorist remains responsible for defining the measurement problem and clarifying how indicators, indices, measures, or observations relate to the theoretical construct.

2. **Empirical study execution and data collection**

Running experiments, observational studies, clinical studies, field studies, surveys, or other empirical designs can be delegated to empirical researchers or domain specialists. The theorist remains responsible for specifying what the study is meant to test, what evidence would be relevant, and how the results should bear on the theory.

3. **Formalization, mathematical proof, and computational implementation**

Coding simulations, building computational models, deriving formal results, or producing mathematical proofs can be delegated to computational modelers, mathematicians, statisticians, or research software engineers. The theorist remains responsible for ensuring that the formal representation faithfully represents the theory and that its assumptions are theoretically interpretable.

4. **Building tests or instruments that manifest construct validity**

Developing concrete tests, tasks, instruments, or assessment procedures can be delegated to test developers, psychometricians, diagnosticians, or empirical specialists. The theorist remains responsible for clarifying what construct-valid behavior would mean in relation to the theory's propositions.

5. **Theory-guided empirical programme execution**

Designing and running a sequence of empirical studies can be collaborative or delegated. The theorist may help design or guide the research programme, but does not need to personally execute every observational, experimental, interventional, formal, or measurement-related study.

6. **Applied translation and intervention development**

Translating a theory into clinical, educational, organizational, policy, or other applied settings can be delegated to applied researchers and domain experts. The theorist remains responsible for clarifying the theoretical implications, assumptions, scope conditions, and expected intervention-relevant consequences.



7. Digital infrastructure for archiving and reusing theories

Building repositories, databases, version-control systems, dashboards, documentation platforms, or other infrastructure for archiving and reusing theories can be delegated to software developers, data stewards, or infrastructure specialists. The theorist remains responsible for deciding what theoretical content, assumptions, versions, revisions, and open questions should be documented.

8. FAIR documentation and project logistics

Maintaining records of activities, decisions, procedures, evidence, failed attempts, revisions, and version histories can be supported by project managers, data stewards, or research assistants. The theorist remains responsible for ensuring that documentation preserves the theory's meaning, evidential status, and revision history.

9. Communication materials and educational adaptation

Producing diagrams, summaries, teaching materials, visualizations, dashboards, tutorials, or other communication products can be delegated to designers, educators, or communication specialists. The theorist remains responsible for ensuring that the theory is communicated accurately and remains usable by relevant scientific audiences.

10. Domain-specific evaluation of indicators, mechanisms, and contexts

Judging the suitability of specific indicators, mechanisms, levels, populations, settings, or applications may require expertise from specialists in psychology, sociology, anthropology, neuroscience, clinical practice, education, or other domains. The theorist remains responsible for coordinating these judgments within the theory's construct architecture, explanatory structure, and scope conditions.

11. Collaborative theory-testing and adversarial evaluation procedures

Organizing adversarial collaborations, critical-friend procedures, peer evaluation, or structured theory-comparison exercises can be shared with collaborators or facilitators. The theorist remains responsible for clarifying which theoretical claims are under evaluation and what outcomes would count for or against them.

12. Routine literature search, evidence retrieval, and bibliography management

Searching the literature, extracting evidence, managing references, and maintaining evidence tables can be delegated to research assistants or information specialists. The theorist remains responsible for judging which evidence is theoretically relevant and how it affects the theory's status, scope, or revision path.